



THE MANY FACES OF BIMAL JALAN

From picking a particular seat in the movie theatre every time to keeping a folder of excuses to decline invitations, **Tamal Bandyopadhyay** brings you unknown facets of the former RBI governor in his latest book

112 |

EVEN TODAY, PEOPLE in the Reserve Bank of India have been trying to figure out the real Bimal Jalan. A politician? A diplomat who can keep everybody happy? A statesman?

He was a pragmatic governor, liberal at heart—a general physician who would decide what to do with a patient by feeling their pulse. Y.V. Reddy, in contrast, was a specialist who would first recommend a diagnostic study to see what was wrong with the patient.

All in the RBI swear by Jalan's ability to get to the core of an issue, cutting the flab. He would come to the office at 9.30 am and leave at 5 pm, come what may. He would watch good movies at theatres and eat at restaurants across Mumbai. Booking an advance ticket.

For him, for the evening show of a movie on its first day (after rave reviews) was not easy as he had a very special seat preference—down to the row and the seat number. Why? Not for the vantage point for watch-

ing the film but for creating the least inconvenience to others. Jalan would walk into the dark auditorium when the film was about to begin and leave a minute before it ended without disturbing others. During the interval, he would stay put, but he would pick such a seat that there would not be much public glare on him.

Among the many new practices that he introduced in the Indian central bank is a bimonthly lunch with a select group of journalists where great non-vegetarian food, ranging from stuffed pomfret to prawn balchao and *badami murgh* would be served, all from the RBI kitchen run by chef Brian Pais. Jalan, a foodie, is a strict vegetarian. While out of Mumbai, be it Lucknow or Patna, Jalan would take his car out in the morning and stop at roadside stalls to have hot sweet tea in a *kulhad* and jalebi, *kachori*, samosa, or *litti-chokha*. Yes, the RBI governor at a roadside stall. Reddy continued with this but changed the menu, introducing Hyderabad biryani. Reddy's

passion for non-vegetarian food and sweets is well known.

My former colleague Niranjan Rajadhyaksha got a taste of this. Once, he met Reddy at the RBI's regional office in Hyderabad. Another RBI governor, D. Subbarao, was also there. By that time, both had retired.

While leaving for the airport to fly back to Mumbai, Rajadhyaksha told Reddy that he would pick up some biryani from a particular restaurant. Reddy advised him to avoid that restaurant and recommended another. At that point, Subbarao stepped in and suggested a third, as Reddy was not familiar with the new restaurants that had come up. Two past RBI governors arguing over which restaurant in Hyderabad serves the best biryani was quite a sight. Reddy even offered to take Rajadhyaksha to Nizam Club for biryani and *double ka meetha* dessert, another name for *shahi-tukda*, made with fried bread soaked in hot milk and sugar syrup with some dry fruits.

Jalan's doors were always open for bankers who wanted to see him. Typically, he would meet them after lunch, between 2.30 pm and 4 pm. The serious meetings happened before lunch, between 11 am and noon. Talking about his meetings, I must mention one. I was not a witness to it, but there are people who can vouch for it.

WHAT BANK STRIKE?

The AIBEA, the most powerful bank employees' union, which was linked to the Communist Party of India, had given a call for an indefinite nationwide bank strike. Tarakeswar Chakraborty, the king of bank unions, wanted to meet Jalan before the strike. Samir Ghosh, the general secretary of the RBI Employees' Union, coordinated the meeting but was not present. At the appointed hour, a day before the strike, Chakraborty walked into the meeting room with two regional leaders in tow. A posse of union members waited outside the RBI main gate,